PROJECT SYNDICATE DIGEST

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1. The Politics of Poland’s Judicial Crisis

Author: Maciej Kisilowski **Published:** Nov 1, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WARSAW—Dramatic scenes are playing out at Poland’s Constitutional Tribunal amid a wave of speculation about whether Prime Minister Donald Tusk’s government and the Tribunal judges elected by its liberal parliamentary majority are acting lawfully. Many will ask whether democrats must break the law to restore institutions sabotaged by populist authoritarians. In the Polish case, it’s the wrong question.

2. A Tory Mentor for the MAGA GOP

Author: Michael R. Strain **Published:** Nov 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—“There is a fight coming in British politics. A fight that we have not seen in this country for more than half a century. It will be a battle for the soul of this nation. A battle of ideas. A battle that goes to the very core of who we are and what kind of country we want to be.”

3. If AI Thinks for Us, Democracy Will Suffer

Author: John Palfrey **Published:** Nov 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

CHICAGO—Sometime in the 18th century, the Enlightenment settled a contentious, centuries-old question: Where does knowledge come from? For millennia, many people had pointed to God. But the early modern period brought a new consensus, namely that knowledge comes from human scientists working at the edge of what is known, armed with observation, mathematics, experimentation, and logic.

4. A Debtors’ Club for a Fragmented World

Author: Ishac Diwan **Published:** Nov 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BANGKOK—For seven decades, some of the world’s biggest official creditors have coordinated their positions in negotiations with debtor countries struggling with repayment. The Paris Club has sought not only to tackle debt treatment for individual sovereigns, but also to shape the rules governing bailouts and conditionality, largely by leveraging its 22 permanent members’ influence at the International Monetary Fund. Now, the world’s debtors have created a club of their own. The question is whether its stated goals are sufficiently ambitious.

5. Trump’s Tariff Fiasco Could Save Free Trade

Author: Anne O. Krueger **Published:** Nov 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—In the nearly two years since he returned to the White House, US President Donald Trump has picked up where he left off in his first term, shredding the open multilateral trading system that has served the world so well since the end of World War II. He has imposed sweeping tariffs on dozens of countries, repeatedly raising and lowering them and changing rates on individual goods and countries, seemingly on a whim. As a result, US tariff rates are now higher than at any time since the Great Depression’s Smoot-Hawley tariffs.

6. Europe’s Bright Future

Author: Thomas Buberl **Published:** Nov 3, 2026 **Link:** View Original

PARIS—I was born in Germany, I studied in Switzerland and the United Kingdom, and I served as a reserve officer in the French Navy. Today, I am a French citizen leading a French company that operates in more than 50 countries. I am, above all, a European.

7. Poland’s Constitutional Civil War

Author: Sławomir Sierakowski **Published:** Nov 3, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WARSAW—In a shocking moment that went viral, Polish President Karol Nawrocki and his cronies were recently filmed breaking into the Constitutional Tribunal in the dead of night and brutally shoving aside the judges they encountered, including an elderly woman. What or who were they coming for?

8. The Tech Brotherhood Wants Sovereignty

Author: Katharina Pistor **Published:** Nov 3, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—Over several centuries, nation-states have come to define the international system and govern much of humanity. After emerging in modern Europe and spreading through colonialism, they eventually made it to every corner of the world through postwar decolonization. Their defining feature is control over territory and its inhabitants, without interference by others.

9. The Far Right’s Vision for Europe

Author: Mark Leonard **Published:** Nov 3, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BERLIN—Recent events have cast European politics into sharper relief. With left-wing protests, some violent, engulfing cities from Paris to Milan to Madrid, the right has remained focused on big upcoming elections, and most mainstream parties appeared to be in retreat. It may be too soon to guess at the outcomes in Spain, France, Poland, and Italy, but there can be little doubt that far-right and populist ideas will shape the Europe that emerges from these contests. That much is clear to me after spending the past few months talking to leading “new right” politicians and strategists in France, Poland, Germany, and Italy.

10. Oligarchic World Order

Author: David Lingelbach **Published:** Nov 3, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BALTIMORE/BOGOTÁ—For most people, the word “oligarch” conjures images of Russian elites who amassed huge fortunes in the wake of the Soviet Union’s collapse or, more recently, the tech billionaires who filled the front row at US President Donald Trump’s second inauguration. But oligarchs are global, systemic, and increasingly entrenched. They are a defining feature of the emerging world order.

11. The Rise and Fall of Privacy

Author: Tiffany Jenkins **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—In the 17th century, a common injunction held that you should “do nothing privately that you would not do publicly. Task yourself, lest privacy becomes your enemy.” Going further, one preacher even warned that privacy was for “adulterers and murderers.” The devil comes to you when you are on your own. You should find it reassuring to be watched.

12. The ECB Must Bail Out France

Author: Desmond Lachman **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—The grandiose claim that “Britannia rules the waves” inspired the wry quip that, in fact, Britannia waives the rules. While the pun was meant as a putdown, waiving rules can be a prudent decision. That is certainly the case for the European Central Bank today, as it weighs its options for helping France, Europe’s second-largest economy, cope with its $4 trillion debt.

13. Dot-Com Lessons for the AI Bubble

Author: Chi Onwurah **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—It is a truth universally acknowledged that transformative new technologies rewrite the rules of finance. Or so we are told in numerous commentaries, social-media posts, and regulatory filings relating to the current AI investment boom, which may well prove to be a bubble.

14. A Fatal Challenge to Mainstream Economics

Author: James K. Galbraith **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

KASHGAR—In what is best read as a preemptive swipe at Isabella Weber’s new book, Anti-Fascist Economics, Jason Furman, the chair of the White House Council of Economic Advisers during US President Barack Obama’s second term, recently offered the following half-truth: “the fatal challenge to heterodox economics is that there isn’t actually orthodox economics.”

15. China Is Defanging the Dollar, Not Dethroning It

Author: Ho-fung Hung **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—After Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022, the United States sought to freeze Russia out of the global financial system, leading many to speculate that weaponization of the US dollar's dominance of that system would accelerate the world's shift away from the greenback. Speculation only intensified when the US launched its war against Iran earlier this year and tightened its financial sanctions on the country.

16. Good Institutions Require Good People

Author: Deirdre Nansen McCloskey **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—We should have learned by now that good politics depends not so much on good institutions as on the moral sentiments supporting them. If bad or unwise people take over your country by coup or by vote, you can’t rely on your institutions to save you. “Add institutions and stir” has never been a consistent recipe for success; good and wise people are.

17. The Democrats' Historic Duty

Author: Reed Galen **Published:** Nov 5, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—Twenty years. Thirty years. Eighty years, and even 90. Some of the positions Democratic candidates won in Tuesday's midterm elections, from Senate seats to attorneys-general, have not had a blue occupant in decades. The outcome of this election, even more than the 2018 midterms, could reshape American politics and policy for years to come. But if the Democrats are to make the most of their gains, they must be ambitious—even audacious.

18. Put the Ocean at the Center of COP31

Author: Peter Thomson **Published:** Nov 5, 2026 **Link:** View Original

MELBOURNE—For over 30 years, Pacific island countries have issued the same warning at the annual United Nations Climate Change Conference: the warming ocean threatens not just food and energy security, but global survival itself. And almost every year, our warning has been treated as a regional problem, a challenge confined to remote small islands and thus not warranting more than lip service from international leaders.

I wish I could say we were wrong. Instead, the climate devastation unfolding before our eyes, supercharged by an El Niño cycle and record-breaking ocean heat, proves that this crisis does not stop at the shoreline.

Rising sea levels are swallowing fertile farmland, displacing communities, and driving up insurance premiums for families. Ocean warming threatens the energy grids and ports that power the world economy and keep global supply chains running. In the Arctic, 60% of coastal infrastructure, much of which is used for critical security activities, has become vulnerable to erosion. In 2024, the Mediterranean and Black Sea, major fishing and aquaculture hubs that generate $21.5 billion in direct and indirect revenue per year, experienced marine heat waves with temperatures nearly 5° Celsius above normal, raising concerns about food insecurity.

Another overlooked factor is the ocean's role as the planet's largest carbon and heat sink, absorbing 30% of CO2 emissions—as much as the world's forests—and capturing 90% of the excess heat generated by those emissions. But it pays the price: the most heat-sensitive ecosystems are underwater, and every fraction of a degree of global warming beyond the 1.5°C target set by the Paris climate agreement destroys more of them. By 2050, under a 2°C warming scenario, the losses caused by ocean-linked disasters could reach $56 billion, exposing the hard limits of adaptation and the urgent need to keep warming as close to 1.5°C as possible.

These are not trivial problems. They imply major global economic and security risks. And they have existential implications for Pacific island countries: staying below the 1.5°C limit is a matter of survival, which is why we fought so fiercely to secure the Paris climate agreement and, in the intervening years, to stick as closely as possible to that target.

Last year's UN Climate Change Conference in Belém, Brazil, put forests at the center of the climate agenda. This month's UN Climate Change Conference (COP31) in Antalya, Turkey, can do the same for the ocean. Political support for ocean-based climate action is strong: more than 100 countries signed a letter declaring that the ocean is a core part of the Paris climate agreement and should be treated as such at COP31.

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In practice, this means that negotiators should include the ocean prominently in discussions about reducing emissions, building resilience, and climate finance. Moreover, the latest ocean science must inform the next global stocktake, which would add a level of accountability to climate action by creating ocean-related commitments that countries must report on and standards against which they are measured.

Every country with a coastline should join the Blue NDC Challenge, a group of governments committed to meeting their national climate goals through ocean-based solutions. The ocean can help accelerate the energy transition with the greening of ports and shipping, as well as the development of offshore renewables. Of course, the blue whale in the room is the oil and gas industry. Rapidly shifting away from fossil fuels is the most effective way to reduce the pressure on coral reefs, fisheries, coastal economies, and the local communities that depend on them.

Investment flows must reflect this rising ambition. Current financing for marine protection is estimated at $1.8 billion per year, leaving a gap of approximately $14 billion. And while many proven solutions are ready to scale, coalitions must be mobilized to ensure that marine protected areas can deliver returns through sustainable fishing and tourism revenues.

For too long, the message of Pacific island countries has fallen on deaf ears. COP31 offers a chance to change that. The health of the ocean will shape the future for all people. Now is the time for everyone to accept that it is a shared asset—and a shared responsibility.

19. Why Aren’t We Investing More in Climate Adaptation?

Author: Mekala Krishnan **Published:** Nov 5, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BOSTON/GENEVA/SEATTLE—As world leaders gather in Antalya, Turkey, for the United Nations Climate Change Conference (COP31), climate adaptation is high on the agenda. The economic case for action is compelling. Measures ranging from flood defenses to cooling and irrigation technologies can prevent losses—including property damage, lower productivity, and reduced agricultural yields—worth many times their cost. Yet the world invests only a fraction of what’s needed, leaving many people and assets inadequately protected from extreme weather.

The McKinsey Global Institute (MGI) found that the world spends approximately $190 billion annually on 20 proven adaptation measures that protect against heat, wildfire, flooding, and drought. But this is just one-third of the $540 billion needed to protect everyone exposed to climate hazards at developed-economy standards. These measures could cost $1.2 trillion per year when the world reaches 2° Celsius above pre-industrial levels, which current emissions trajectories suggest may occur by around 2050. But we estimate that the returns in avoided losses would be roughly three times the costs of these measures today, increasing to seven times the costs at 2°C of warming.

Clearly, economic benefits are not enough to guarantee investment. The problem is that what makes economic sense for society does not always make financial sense for the households, companies, and governments expected to act. Consider the construction of a sea dike. It protects residents, businesses, property owners, and insurers from flood losses, but the public agency building it has no way to recover its costs, because a sea dike does not produce revenue. Similarly, a bank may struggle to finance an asset with no predictable cash flow.

New research from MGI examining investment barriers across 20 measures finds two preconditions for climate adaptation: households, companies, and governments must be willing and able to implement measures, and capital providers must be willing to finance them on acceptable terms. Competing spending priorities, unclear benefits, misaligned incentives, and implementation challenges can constrain demand, while repayment risks, uncertain project performance, and the difficulty of making numerous small investments can impede financing even where demand exists.

While these barriers often reinforce one another, they are not universal. By 2050, we estimate that measures representing roughly $460 billion in annual adaptation costs—about 40% of the total needed—could be “deployment ready,” facing minimal demand or financing constraints. Beyond protecting lives and livelihoods, these measures, which range from cooling systems to stormwater management, represent a potential market opportunity for adaptation providers and financiers, and over two-thirds of this opportunity is expected to be in higher-income regions.

But substantial obstacles stand in the way of unlocking the remaining $690 billion in annual adaptation costs required at 2°C, particularly in the least protected places. In India and Sub-Saharan Africa, adaptation costs could reach 2–3% of GDP, compared with 0.3–0.5% in higher-income regions. At the same time, less than 20% of adaptation investment needed in these regions is expected to be deployment ready, compared with more than half in higher-income regions, implying a need for innovation in how adaptation is delivered and financed.

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Three issues need to be addressed. First, adaptation must become more affordable for households struggling to make ends meet, as about $440 billion in annual adaptation needs could be blocked by competing spending priorities and a lack of creditworthiness. That means cheaper technologies and financing. For example, the municipal authorities in Ahmedabad,

India, worked with the Mahila Housing Trust to reduce the cost of heat-reflecting roofs for low-income households through subsidies, credit schemes, and coordinated implementation.

Second, stronger incentives, clearer evidence of benefits, and improved capabilities could unlock about $210 billion in annual adaptation costs. To create more space for rivers to flood safely, the Netherlands' Room for the River program had to convince some landowners to relinquish their property or change how their land was used, even as the benefits of the program accrued broadly across communities. The program implemented more than 30 projects by aligning incentives through compensation, property purchases, and relocation support, and by coordinating between national and local governments, water authorities, and communities.

Finally, demand exists for the remaining $40 billion in required adaptation measures blocked by barriers, but these projects must be made bankable through innovative revenue mechanisms and financing structures, or with evidence of reliable performance to reduce investor risk. The Drought Tolerant Maize for Africa initiative demonstrates how early-stage funding can help establish a track record for emerging adaptation solutions. Donors supported years of research and field testing, while partnerships with local seed companies helped scale production and distribution. By 2014, drought-tolerant seeds had reached an estimated 5.4 million households.

There are many proven ways to protect people and assets from extreme weather. But advancing adaptation will require each stakeholder to play its part. Companies should integrate climate resilience into investment decisions and develop more affordable adaptation measures. Financial institutions should create financing structures that better capture the economic value of avoided losses. And governments should strengthen incentives, coordinate implementation, and direct scarce public resources toward investments that markets alone cannot deliver.

Adaptation has been shown time and again to deliver substantial economic value. The challenge now is to ensure that those who need to invest have the means—and the incentives—to do so.

20. Turning Sub-Saharan Africa’s Cities Into Job Engines

Author: Paschal Donohoe **Published:** Nov 5, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—Recent visits to South Africa and Ghana brought home to me the scale of Africa’s urban development opportunity. In Johannesburg and Accra, I saw fast-growing cities, teeming with ambition, innovation, and young people looking to build better lives. Their challenges are significant, but so, too, is their potential to create jobs and drive growth.

21. Why Are Indian Protesters Targeting the Electoral Commission?

Author: Shashi Tharoor **Published:** Nov 5, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW DELHI—Following a summer of discontent, India has entered an autumn of political crisis. During a scorching June and July, a youth-led movement, backed by Rahul Gandhi's opposition Congress party, took to the streets to demand education reform. So potent was the movement that the central government, led by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), was forced to make significant concessions, including the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. But Indians are not finished: they have now set their sights on the electoral system.

22. Can AI Colonialism Be Prevented?

Author: Jayant Sinha **Published:** Nov 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW DELHI—The world is entering the AI age with the United States and China having established clear technological dominance over all other countries. These two superpowers now control virtually every layer of the “stack”: the hardware, data systems, software, and apps that, together, compose AI. They are also investing in AI infrastructure at a pace other countries cannot match.

23. MAGA’s Midterm Defeat Won’t Change the Course of History

Author: Slavoj Žižek **Published:** Nov 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LJUBLJANA—My duty as a philosopher is to spoil the ecstatic sense of relief that has followed the US midterm elections. Yes, at first glance, we all triumphed: not only did Donald Trump’s party suffer a spectacular defeat, but Trump even accepted his loss and promised to work with the incoming Democratic Congress. We were spared the state of emergency or canceled results that so many had feared.

24. Making the Most of America’s Midterm Tsunami

Author: Aziz Huq **Published:** Nov 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

CHICAGO—Imagine, for a moment, that the US midterm elections had not delivered Democratic wins at a generational scale, but merely a trickle of flipped seats—enough, perhaps, to change control of the House of Representatives but not enough for a Senate majority. Is there any doubt that President Donald Trump would embrace such results as a good-enough validation of his often lawless and brutal administration? Would it not now be doubling down, striving to cast the polls as an imprimatur for its excesses?

25. The Economic Toll of Israel’s Wars

Author: Joseph Zeira **Published:** Nov 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

JERUSALEM—Israel’s election results make weeks of political negotiation all but certain. What is equally clear is that whatever government eventually takes office will need to begin reckoning with the mounting costs of Israel’s ongoing wars.

26. Only Israel’s Arab Parties Can Restore Its Democracy

Author: Shlomo Ben-Ami **Published:** Nov 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

TEL AVIV—Before Israel’s election, I warned that no one should pin high hopes on the outcome. Sadly, that advice has been vindicated. An electorate deeply split along tribal and cultural lines did not hold Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu accountable for multiple prolonged wars, overseeing countless war crimes, and decimating Israel’s global standing. Instead, the vote delivered a deadlock.

27. Rebalancing Nature’s Books

Author: Homi Kharas **Published:** Nov 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—Four years ago, the United Nations Biodiversity Conference in Montreal adopted the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework, hailed at the time as the “Paris agreement for nature.” But the first assessment of the framework’s implementation, released at October’s UN Biodiversity Conference (COP17) in Yerevan, makes for sobering reading. The State of Biodiversity Action report finds that while nearly 90% of countries have set targets to protect 30% of land and sea areas, restore 30% of degraded ecosystems, and halt human-caused extinctions, fewer than half of the assessed targets are on track to be met by 2030.

UN Secretary-General António Guterres called COP17 “our moment of accountability.” But while accountability is long overdue, finding a solution requires accurately diagnosing the problem. The Kunming-Montreal framework is faltering not because governments are indifferent to nature, but because global economic and financial systems reward nature’s destruction and penalize its protection. According to the UN Environment Programme, in 2023, $7.3 trillion—roughly 7% of world GDP—flowed into activities that directly harm nature. For every dollar invested in nature that year, $30 was spent destroying it.

The Kunming-Montreal framework calls for closing the biodiversity finance gap, which amounts to $700 billion annually, by reducing nature-harming subsidies by $500 billion per year and mobilizing $200 billion per year in incremental finance, including $30 billion from external official sources. Well over half of that investment is needed to implement sustainable management practices for farmland, rangeland, fisheries, and forests. The remainder is for ecosystem restoration and preservation.

The issue is bigger than market failures. As David Obura argues in our co-edited volume Nature, People, and Sustainable Development, there is a fundamental mismatch between what we value and what is needed. At best, prices capture nature’s usefulness. To reflect nature’s relational or intrinsic worth requires reframing the problem as not just conservation, which looks like a cost—land tied up and growth forgone—that rich countries foist on poor ones. Credit-ratings agencies, pointing to the risk of slower growth, then downgrade developing countries’ credit ratings.

A far better approach is to emphasize the bioeconomy’s potential, which positions protecting nature as a growth strategy. Around 55% of global GDP—equivalent to $58 trillion—already depends directly on nature. The bioeconomy, which uses biological resources in a regenerative and nature-positive way, is worth about $4 trillion today; unlocking its potential could boost its value to $30 trillion by 2050 and link producers to global supply chains that can steer them toward higher value-added activities.

The problem of underinvestment is most acute in countries with abundant natural resources but limited fiscal space, including Indonesia, Brazil, Peru, Zambia, Ecuador, the Philippines, and Mozambique. These governments often rely on extractive activities such as logging, mining, and plantation agriculture to earn foreign exchange, which tends to go toward servicing their external debt. The resulting ecological damage leaves them more exposed to floods, droughts, storms, and other climate disasters that usually lead to rating downgrades. By contrast, debt frameworks do not properly account for the benefits of building resilience to such shocks.

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Creating the right incentives is especially important in commodity supply chains. For example, Côte d’Ivoire and Ghana produce nearly two-thirds of the world’s cocoa supply, almost entirely on small farms. But 73–90% of households

producing cocoa in these countries earn little income from it, and cannot afford the fertilizer and weed-control costs of replanting aging trees, so they push into forests where it is cheaper to plant new ones.

But with chocolate trading, processing, and manufacturing concentrated in a handful of firms, a few players can have an outsize impact on global outcomes. The European Union, which imports about 58% of the world's cocoa beans, will begin to apply the Deforestation Regulation to large operators starting in December, making access to the European market for cocoa, coffee, and other commodities conditional on deforestation-free supply chains. But to improve compliance, some of the big traders should be encouraged to finance replanting and traceability efforts, so that smallholder farmers can meet the rules and earn more by doing so.

Protecting nature is also a security imperative, with environmental crime—illegal logging, mining, wildlife trafficking, and fishing—generating an estimated $110–280 billion per year, much of it laundered through the same channels as proceeds from narcotics and illicit finance. Instead of chasing individual loggers, enforcement and asset recovery should target chokepoints like mills, refineries, ports, traders, and financiers, while securing land rights and public finance for nature's most effective stewards: Indigenous peoples and local communities, whose relationships with nature reflect its relational and intrinsic values.

The lesson of the State of Biodiversity Action report is that adding targets while treating nature as just another economic sector will not work. As the future of climate and nature action are once again negotiated at this month's UN Climate Change Conference (COP31) in Antalya and in discussions at the UN about the agenda to replace the Sustainable Development Goals after 2030, we must focus on changing the incentives that have stalled progress. That means framing nature as an investment, not a cost—and rewarding, not punishing, those who protect it.

28. AI Can Help Governments Help Citizens

Author: Kalpana Kochhar **Published:** Nov 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—Many countries are trying to do more for their citizens, albeit often with outdated systems. That means accessing government services can feel like a second job. A mother walks half a day to a clinic, only to be turned away because she needs a form from an office in another town. A farmer who qualifies for financial support gives up after being passed from queue to queue. AI, if used correctly, could help close these gaps, expanding a capable state's reach.

For low- and middle-income countries, the stakes could not be higher: AI could be a great equalizer, or it could deepen inequality. While AI's likely contributions to agriculture, health care, and education hold great promise, the World Bank's World Development Report 2026 estimates that AI's productivity benefits could be more than twice as large in advanced economies if current trends continue. The technology's future trajectory depends on the decisions that developers, investors, and governments make today about how it is built, funded, and deployed.

As Kristalina Georgieva, managing director of the International Monetary Fund, explained at the IMF-World Bank Annual Meetings in October, AI adoption depends on electricity access, digital connectivity, and workers equipped with the right skills. But after decades spent in development finance, I am convinced that access, while a legitimate concern, is not the biggest barrier. Above all, AI adoption requires building the state capacity to put these tools to use.

In advanced economies, the AI debate has largely focused on safety, security, and the threat of job displacement. But in developing economies, the more immediate question is how to ensure that AI tools actually serve people. They must work in local languages, train on local data, and be built for local realities. And they must be coupled with investment in the institutions and people closest to the problem, who understand where AI tools can deliver real benefits and can ensure that they do. Much of this essential work falls to the companies building these tools and the funders backing them.

But even the best-built tools will struggle to deliver results if governments lack the capacity to implement them. Creating that capacity requires integrating AI systems into existing programs. Consider MahaVISTAAR, a free AI advisory service that the Indian state of Maharashtra built for farmers to ask about crops, weather, and pests in their own language through an app, voice call, or chat. So far, more than 740,000 farmers have joined, with 70,000 new users signing up each month, at a cost to the government of less than 18 cents per farmer—a fraction of what it would cost to reach them in person. The tool worked because the government viewed it as a new layer of public infrastructure built on its network for advising farmers, rather than a one-off app.

On a recent visit to Pakistan, I witnessed a provincial government working to build this kind of capacity, which it views as a public good. Punjab has established a government office dedicated to AI and is collaborating with local researchers to develop public-health applications, including local-language tools that help frontline workers reach mothers with the right guidance at the right time.

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AI tools intended to serve citizens must work within government, not merely be adapted to it. They must be built to run on public systems and data, adhere to the data-sharing and security protocols that policymakers have selected for their countries, and be affordable enough for governments to procure and sustain them.

In my experience, three elements are essential to building AI capacity. First, governments need leaders who can determine the best use cases for AI, alongside institutional ownership and cross-ministry coordination. An AI strategy needs a clear budget and detailed timelines, and should be backed by empowered ministries and a mechanism that makes

decisions binding across agencies. This could reduce the likelihood of parallel projects, which may result in duplication and suboptimal outcomes, eroding the limited capability that already exists.

Second, countries need civil servants with enough AI expertise to commission, acquire, integrate, evaluate, and regulate these systems. That means developing talent pipelines that channel people with the necessary technical skills—distinct from general digital literacy—toward government roles. While not even wealthy countries have figured out how to meet this demand, developing countries can hardly afford to neglect it.

Third, governments must build integrated digital public infrastructure, including e-government service delivery, digital ID, payments, and a secure data exchange layer. Weak digitization and fragmented vertical systems are a direct constraint on AI performance and safety. Once that infrastructure is in place, AI can in turn help make government systems more secure—detecting fraud, cyberattacks, and anomalous patterns.

Building the tools may be the more straightforward part. Whether AI reaches that mother or that farmer will be determined less by the pace of the technology than by the choices governments make now. If policymakers get it right, AI can help a country fulfill its most basic, and most important, duty: serving its citizens effectively.